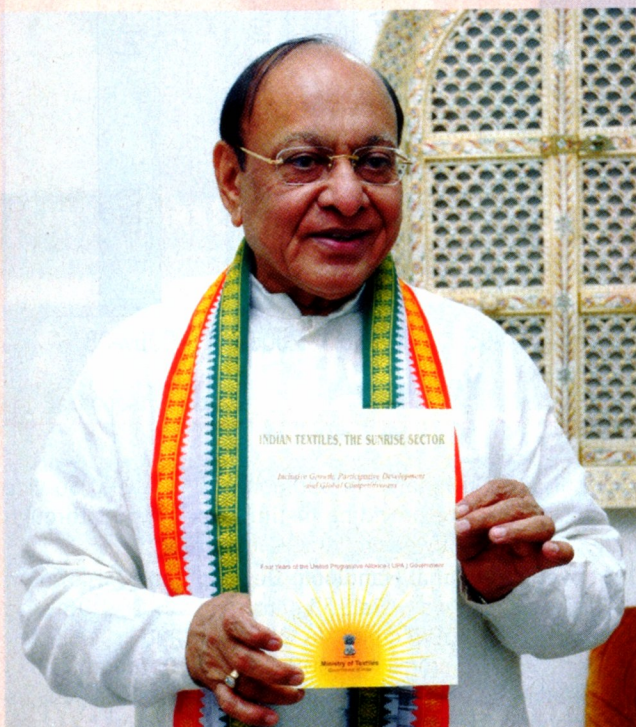


INDIAN HANDICRAFTS

CAPTURE THE IMAGINATION OF THE WORLD



SHRI. SHAKERSINH VAGHELA

Hon'ble Minister of Textiles

The unparalleled dynamism of the Indian Handicrafts Industry propped by tradition and supported by the Ministry of Textiles is on a growth trajectory. The industry, a major source of income for rural communities, has evolved as one of the major revenue generator over the years. The sector is economically important from the point of view of low capital investment, high ratio of value addition, and high potential for export and foreign exchange earnings for the country.

For the growth and development of the sector the Office of the Development Commissioner (handicrafts), Ministry Of Textiles has introduced various initiatives under various schemes of development and promotion to bring Indian Handicrafts at par in the global arena, like

- Baba Saheb Ambedkar Hastshilp Vikas Yojna (AHVY)
- Handicraft Artisans Comprehensive Welfare Scheme
- Gandhi Shilp Bazaar

BABASAHEB AMBEDKAR HASTSHILP VIKAS YOJNA (AHVY)

Handicrafts constitute an important segment of the de-centralized/unorganized sector of our economy. It is mainly rural based, having reach in backward and in-accessible area. Originally, started as a part time activity in rural areas, it has now transformed into a flourishing economic activity due to significant market demand over the years. Handicrafts have big potential as they hold the key for sustaining not only the existing set of millions of artisans spread over length and breadth of the country, but also for increasingly large number of new entrants in the crafts activity. Presently, handicrafts sector is contributing substantially in employment generation and export but this sector has suffered due to very

nature of being unorganized with additional constraints like lack of education, capital, poor exposure to new technologies, absence of market intelligence and poor institutional framework. In order to overcome these constraints, Baba Saheb Ambedkar Hastashilp Vikas Yojana (BAHVY) was launched in IXth plan period wherein the main thrust is on a projectised, need based approach for integrated development of potential handicrafts clusters with participation of the craft persons at all stages of implementation of the scheme with the ultimate objective of their empowerment and hence sustainability.

The scheme envisages a package of support to the cluster of handicraft artisans, which inter-alia includes basic inputs and infrastructure support in addition to capacity enhancement to cater to target markets. While it is an undisputed fact that the Govt. of India and the State Governments have intervened in meaningful ways that have led to the revival and survival of crafts in the past few decades, in the light of new economic developments of one global unified market, handicrafts sector of India has to be strengthened further to be globally competitive. There is therefore, compelling urgency to fill in critical gaps, which have been taken care of in the scheme based on CLUSTER APPROACH.

The scheme is primarily artisans centric, launched in the IXth Five Year Plan, is being continued in the XIth Plan Period. The scheme supports the cluster artisans in up gradation of their existing skill level, Development of new design which are having demand in the domestic and international market, provide the artisans with improved modern tools, common work sheds - a hygienic workplace to the artisans' groups to work and store their artifacts, assistance for exhibitions to show case their products, assistance to create brochures, catalogues, folders, video films, etc.

In XIth plan emphasis is given on Development of infrastructure related facilities in clusters such as setting up of Raw Material Banks to ensure easy & continuous availability of Graded raw materials, Common Facility Centres with improved modern sophisticated machineries to augment the bulk export requirements, support the artisans' federation to set up their own show rooms and emporia, access to information through E-Kiosks at clusters. Besides the exporters and the entrepreneurs can avail the assistance of setting up of Facility Centres scheme to modernize and up grade their existing production units on Public-Private- Partnership (PPP) mode.

In terms of its achievement, since the IXth five year Plan till 2007-08, 848 projects have been sanctioned covering 2,65,000 artisans spread across the country. These 2,65,000 handicrafts artisans have been grouped in to 15,200 Self Help Groups (SHGs). In order to augment the production capacity 104 CFC's and 6 Raw Material Banks have been sanctioned. Up to 2007-08, Financial assistance to the tune of Rs. 127.4 crores has been released under this scheme.

These projects are being implemented through the Non Government Organizations (NGOs), State and Central Handicrafts Corporations, Apex Co-operative Societies, State and Central government Departments, DRDA, etc.

HANDICRAFT ARTISANS COMPREHENSIVE WELFARE SCHEME

During the 10th Plan, the following two independent welfare schemes had been implemented:

- Bima Yojana for Handicraft Artisans** – Launched in 2003-04 and implemented through LIC of India. During the 10th Plan period 3,11,497 artisans have been covered.

Bima Yojana for Handicraft Artisans

- The objective of this component is to provide life insurance protection to